

Safeguarding & Abuse Prevention

Youth sport programs comply with best practices in safeguarding and abuse prevention.

The welfare of youth in sport must extend beyond physical injury prevention to encompass a comprehensive safeguarding framework. This standard begins with rigorous screening (e.g., background checks, references) for all staff and volunteers. Organizations must equip all personnel with training to prevent, identify, respond to, and report emotional, physical, and sexual abuse. A robust code of conduct must underpin this training.

However, true safeguarding extends beyond compliance with minimum requirements. It requires building a culture where everyone - coaches, administrators, parents/guardians, and athletes - understand that protecting young people is a collective responsibility. This means moving from a checklist mentality to an organizational culture that prioritizes continuous improvement, empowers bystanders to intervene, establishes clear behavioral standards, and removes barriers to reporting concerns.

The implementation section that follows this guideline presents progressive strategies, from foundational screening to advanced cultural practices, that together create a robust safeguarding system. As you review this section, consider both your program's current strengths—existing strategies that promote youth mental health—and its gaps, where additional or enhanced approaches may be needed.

The recommended approach is to begin with a foundational level of implementation across all guidelines, then progressively strengthen implementation by going deeper within each guideline.

Effective implementation occurs along a continuum toward exemplary practice; it is neither expected nor feasible to implement every strategy at once.

Guideline Implementation Protocol

1 Complete Background Checks

Background checks are the foundational screening tool to prevent individuals with histories of abuse or misconduct from accessing youth. This is the minimum compliance requirement and establishes a baseline of safety before individuals begin working with young people.

Implementation:

- Conduct comprehensive background checks on all staff and volunteers who work directly with young people before they begin their roles.
- Background checks should include: criminal history searches (state and national), sex offender registry checks, and employment reference verification.
- Establish clear disqualification criteria based on the nature and severity of offenses.
- Re-screen all staff and volunteers at regular intervals, typically every 2-3 years.
- Maintain secure, confidential records of all background checks in compliance with applicable laws.
- Consult the National Council of Youth Sports (NCYS) Guidelines for recommended best practices on screening and selection.

2 Require SafeSport or Equivalent Abuse Prevention Training

Training equips staff with the knowledge to recognize warning signs of abuse, understand grooming behaviors, respond appropriately to disclosures, and fulfill their legal reporting obligations. This moves beyond screening to active prevention and awareness, creating a first line of defense against abuse.

Implementation:

- All staff and volunteers who work directly with young people must complete evidence-based abuse prevention training (such as U.S. Center for SafeSport training) before beginning their roles.
- Training must cover: recognizing signs and symptoms of abuse, understanding boundary violations and grooming behaviors, responding to disclosures from youth, mandated reporting requirements and procedures, and organizational safeguarding policies.
- Require refresher training every 1-2 years to reinforce concepts and update staff on policy changes.
- Track completion of training and maintain records as part of staff credentialing.

3 Conduct Annual Safeguarding Audits Using a Self-Assessment Tool

Moving from compliance to culture requires regular evaluation and continuous improvement. An annual audit helps organizations identify gaps in their safeguarding practices, measure progress over time, and demonstrate commitment to ongoing development. This strategy shifts the focus from 'checking boxes' to building robust systems that evolve with emerging best practices.

Implementation:

- Designate a safeguarding lead or committee responsible for conducting the annual audit.
- Use a comprehensive safeguarding audit checklist to evaluate current practices across key domains: staff screening and selection, training and education, supervision practices, communication and social media policies, reporting procedures and documentation, physical environment and facility safety, and code of conduct implementation. (link to checklist in appendices)
- Complete the audit annually, documenting both strengths and areas for improvement.
- Consider sharing audit results (in appropriate summary form) with stakeholders including parents/guardians to demonstrate transparency and accountability.

4 Establish Clear Codes of Conduct with Specific Behavioral Standards

Vague policies leave too much to interpretation and make it difficult to address boundary violations early. A detailed code of conduct with specific, observable behavioral standards removes ambiguity, empowers staff to recognize violations, and provides clear grounds for accountability. This creates a shared understanding of acceptable behavior and reduces the 'gray zones' where abuse can occur and thrive.

Implementation:

Develop a comprehensive code of conduct that addresses specific high-risk situations with concrete behavioral standards. These situations may include:

- One-on-one interactions
- Electronic communications and social media
- Travel and overnight stays
- Physical contact and spotting
- Locker room and changing area supervision
- Photography and video

Require all staff and volunteers to sign the code of conduct annually as a condition of participation.

Review the code during staff onboarding and reference specific standards during regular team meetings and training sessions.

Share relevant portions of the code of conduct with parents/guardians and athletes so everyone understands expectations.

Establish clear consequences for code violations, applied consistently regardless of an individual's status or tenure.

5 Implement Bystander Intervention Protocols

Rationale: Culture change happens when everyone in the organization feels empowered and equipped to speak up when they witness concerning behavior. Bystander intervention moves safeguarding from an individual responsibility to a collective one. Many boundary violations occur in the 'gray zone' where behavior is inappropriate but not clearly abusive: these moments require intervention before escalation. Research shows that most abuse could be prevented if bystanders acted when they first witnessed warning signs.

Implementation:

- Train all staff, volunteers, and when age-appropriate, athletes themselves in the principles of effective bystander intervention: recognizing concerning situations, overcoming common barriers to action (diffusion of responsibility, fear of misinterpreting, social consequences), and choosing safe and effective intervention strategies (link to protocols in appendices)
- Develop and distribute pocket-sized reference guides with specific scripts for common scenarios, such as: inappropriate communication or social media contact, boundary violations during travel or overnight stays, one-on-one situations without proper protocols, verbal or emotional abuse of an athlete, and concerns about a colleague's behavior toward youth. (link to template in appendices)
- Create a culture where intervention is expected and supported by leadership. Publicly recognize and thank individuals who speak up about concerns.
- Provide multiple channels for reporting concerns, including anonymous options, to reduce barriers to intervention.

Practice bystander intervention scenarios during staff training and team meetings to build confidence and familiarity with intervention techniques.

Protect staff from retaliation when they report concerns in good faith, even if investigations do not substantiate allegations.

Additional Resources

- **Laureus Sport for Good Safeguarding Policy:** Outlines principles and procedures to protect children, young people, and vulnerable adults, defining reporting procedures and risk mitigation.
- **National Council of Youth Sports (NCYS) Guidelines:** Recommended best practices for screening, selection, and background checks for youth-serving organizations.
- **Praesidium Code of Conduct Resource:** A comprehensive guide for youth sports organizations with recommendations for one-on-one interactions, travel protocols, and electronic communication.
- **U.S. Center for SafeSport:** Online training modules and toolkits for abuse prevention and reporting. Available at safesport.org
- **Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline (800.422.4453):** Pathway for reporting concerns, with anonymous reporting available.

Key Evidence and Supporting Research

Researchers have documented that youth sport environments carry potential for harm, particularly when system-level factors go unaddressed. Additional research has identified harassment and abuse in sport as a public health concern, with coach-athlete power imbalances and competitive pressures elevating risk for youth athletes. Policy frameworks from organizations including the U.S. Center for SafeSport, Keeping Children Safe, and the IOC converge on a core set of baseline protections that include pre-engagement screening, mandatory abuse prevention training, accessible reporting mechanisms, and codes of conduct. Evidence from youth-serving sectors more broadly show that background screening reduces access by individuals with prior abuse histories, and that training improves staff knowledge and reporting confidence.

Key Supporting Research

Massey, W. V., & Whitley, M. A. (2020). The talent paradox: Disenchantment, disengagement, and damage through sport. *Sociology of Sport Journal*, 38(2), 167–177.

Mountjoy, M., Brackenridge, C., Arrington, M., Blauwet, C., Carska-Sheppard, A., Fasting, K., Kirby, S., Leahy, T., Marks, S., Martin, K., Starr, K., Tiivas, A., & Budgett, R. (2016). International Olympic Committee consensus statement: Harassment and abuse (non-accidental violence) in sport. *British Journal of Sports Medicine*, 50(17), 1019–1029.

South, S., Shlonsky, A., & Mildon, R. (2015). Scoping review: Evaluations of pre-employment screening practices for child-related work that aim to prevent child sexual abuse. *Royal Commission into Institutional Responses to Child Sexual Abuse*.

Stirling, A. E., & Kerr, G. A. (2009). Abused athletes' perceptions of the coach-athlete relationship. *Sport in Society*, 12(2), 227–239. Wurtele, S. K. (2012). Preventing the sexual exploitation of minors in youth-serving organizations. *Children and Youth Services Review*, 34(12), 2442–2453.